Datumanong A. Sarangani

Datumanong A. Sarangani (September 17, 1946 – 2011) was a Filipino educator, academic administrator, and scholar from Lanao del Sur, Philippines. He is best remembered for his forty-five years of service at Mindanao State University (MSU), where he served in various capacities — from faculty member, to college secretary, to dean, to chancellor of two MSU campuses, to University Secretary, to Secretary to the Board of Regents, and finally to Executive Vice President (EVP) of the entire MSU System. He entered MSU in 1962 as one of its first 282 students and graduated in 1966 as part of its pioneer batch of 63 graduates, making his personal story almost a mirror image of the university's own growth.

Within the MSU community, he is widely regarded as the "**best President MSU never had**" — a phrase that captures how deeply he was respected not for the title he held, but for the kind of person and leader he was throughout his long career.<ref name="rnc">RNC CREED. (2011, September 15). *Mindanao State University honors Dr. Datumanong Sarangani.* https://rnccreed.wordpress.com/2011/09/15/mindanao-state-university-honors-dr-datumanong-sarangani/</ref>

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Dr. Datumanong A. Sarangani

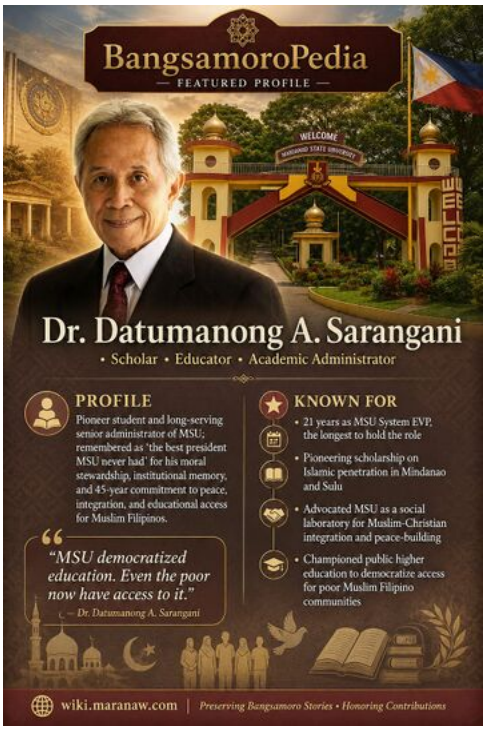


Photo: Courtesy of Ash Tamano

Personal Information

- **Born:** September 17, 1946
- **Birthplace:** Madalum, Lanao del Sur
- **Ethnicity:** Maranao
- **Religion:** Islam

Education

- **Undergraduate:** Mindanao State University (pioneer batch, 1962 — first graduating class, 1966)

Academic and Professional Career

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Background and Early Life

Datumanong A. Sarangani was born on September 17, 1946, in Lanao del Sur, a province in what is now the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM). He grew up in a Maranao Muslim community where Islamic tradition and close-knit clan networks shaped everyday life. Not much has been formally documented about his parents or siblings, but what is clear is that he came from a generation of Muslims who had very limited access to quality higher education in the Philippines.

When Mindanao State University was founded in 1961 through Republic Act No. 1387, it was created specifically to address that problem — to bring educational opportunity to Muslim Filipinos and to test whether Muslim and Christian youth could genuinely study and live together under one roof. Sarangani walked into that experiment in June 1962, just a year after MSU opened its doors.

The campus he arrived at was rough by any standard. Electricity was unreliable. Water supply was inconsistent. Infrastructure was barely in place. He later described those early years at MSU as a "no man's land," where students had to tough it out and lean on each other to get through.<ref name="gcpe">Global Campaign for Peace Education. (2018, September 5). *Teaching peace in the*

- Faculty Member, Mindanao State University
- Chancellor, MSU General Santos (1988 — 1990)
- Chancellor, MSU Marawi (1990 — 1991)
- University Secretary / Secretary to the Board of Regents, MSU System (1990 — 2011)
- Executive Vice President, MSU System (1990 — 2011)

Length of Service

45 years (Mindanao State University)

Field of Scholarship

- Islamic Studies
- Mindanao and Bangsamoro History
- Muslim Filipino Education and Development

Selected Publications

- "Islamic Penetration in Mindanao and Sulu," *Mindanao Journal* (University Research Center, Mindanao State University), Vol. III, January — June 1977

NOTABILITY

Pioneer student and long-serving senior administrator of Mindanao State University; widely regarded within the MSU community as "the best president MSU never had" for his moral stewardship, institutional memory, and 45-year commitment to the university's founding mission of peace, integration, and access to education for Muslim Filipinos.

battleground: Mindanao State University celebrates 57th year. https://www.peace-ed-campaign.org/teaching-peace-in-the-battleground-mindanao-state-university-celebrates-57th-year/</ref> Far from discouraging him, that environment seems to have become the foundation for one of his most enduring beliefs about education: that surviving difficulty together builds something deeper than any classroom lesson alone can offer.

Education

Sarangani earned his undergraduate degree from Mindanao State University, graduating in April 1966 as part of the institution's first-ever graduating class of 63 students.<ref name="msua">Mindanao State University. (n.d.-a). *About us: History of Mindanao State University.* https://www.msumain.edu.ph/about-us/</ref> That milestone was no small thing — these 63 graduates were proof that MSU's founding mission was not just a political idea but a reality.

He later pursued advanced studies and earned a **Doctor of Education (Ed.D.)**, making him one of the early Muslim Filipino scholars who went through a full academic pipeline — from pioneer student to doctoral degree holder — at MSU itself. This put him among the first wave of Muslim Filipino academics whose credentials were earned entirely within a Philippine state university context, rather than through foreign scholarships or metropolitan institutions in Manila.<ref name="msub">Mindanao State University. (n.d.-b). *The MSU System executive vice presidents.* https://www.msumain.edu.ph/office-of-the-executive-vice-president/the-msu-system-executive-vice-presidents/</ref>

KNOWN FOR

- 21-year tenure as Executive Vice President of the MSU System (longest-serving in the role)
- Pioneering scholarship on the history of Islamic penetration in Mindanao and Sulu
- Advocacy for MSU as a social laboratory for Muslim-Christian integration and peace-building
- Championing the role of public higher education in democratizing access for poor Muslim Filipino communities

PULL QUOTE

"MSU democratized education. Even the poor now have access to it."

— Dr. Datumanong A. Sarangani

Career Overview

Faculty Member and Early Academic Work

After graduation, Sarangani joined the MSU faculty in the College of Social Sciences and Humanities, teaching sociology and related subjects.<ref name="msua"/> His early teaching years coincided with a turbulent period in Mindanao — the 1970s and early 1980s saw political upheaval, the declaration of Martial Law, and the rise of the Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF), all of which surrounded MSU even as the university tried to hold on to its mission of integration.

Throughout this period, he chose to remain with MSU, building his reputation through consistent teaching and early scholarly work rather than seeking positions elsewhere.

College Secretary and Dean

Before moving into system-wide positions, Sarangani served in middle-level administrative roles as **college secretary** and later as **dean** within MSU.<ref name="msua"/> These roles introduced him to the practical realities of running an academic unit — faculty evaluation, curriculum oversight, student discipline, and resource

management. Colleagues noted that even at this stage, he showed a preference for documentation, proper procedure, and doing things by the book — habits that would define his later career.

Chancellor, MSU–General Santos City (1988)

In 1988, Sarangani was appointed **Chancellor of MSU–General Santos City**,<ref name="msub"/> one of the constituent campuses of the growing MSU System. The chancellorship gave him responsibility for campus-level governance, and he used that platform to emphasize orderly administration, faculty morale, and academic programs that served the community. His approach to leadership — calm, principled, and transparent — was already visible at this stage.

Chancellor, MSU–Main Campus, Marawi (1990)

Two years later, in 1990, he moved to the most prominent campus in the system, becoming **Chancellor of MSU–Main Campus** in Marawi City.<ref name="msub"/> Marawi was — and still is — the heart of the MSU System and the symbolic center of Muslim Filipino higher education. As chancellor, he continued to prioritize campus peace and order, support for social sciences and Islamic studies, and the kind of transparent administrative processes that reduce room for favoritism or political interference.

University Secretary and Secretary to the Board of Regents (1990)

Also in August 1990, Sarangani took on the dual role of **University Secretary** and **Secretary to the Board of Regents**,<ref name="msub"/> positions that placed him at the center of all official MSU governance. These roles made him the custodian of MSU's official records, the person who authenticated board resolutions, and the coordinator of communications across the university's growing number of campuses. In practice, this made him MSU's institutional memory — the person who knew what had been decided, why, and on what basis.

Executive Vice President, MSU System (1990–2011)

Sarangani served as **Executive Vice President of the MSU System** from 1990 until his retirement on his sixty-fifth birthday, September 17, 2011 — a continuous tenure of **twenty-one years** in the system's top operational role.<ref name="msub"/> As EVP, he functioned as the chief operating officer of the entire MSU System, assisting the president in strategic governance and overseeing day-to-day operations across what had grown into an **eleven-campus system** — one of the largest state university systems in the Philippines.<ref name="msua"/>

What makes this tenure historically unusual is that he held the EVP position continuously across **multiple presidential administrations**, a rare achievement in Philippine public higher education where political transitions typically bring leadership reshuffles. Each successive MSU president chose to retain him — a reflection of the trust and credibility he had built across decades.

Scholarly Work and Intellectual Contributions

Context of Muslim Filipino Scholarship

When Sarangani started writing and doing research, Muslim Filipino scholars were a rare presence in Philippine academic circles. For a long time, Muslims in Mindanao were more often written *about* than given the chance to write for themselves. Sarangani belonged to the generation that began to change that.

His intellectual interests were grounded and practical. Rather than pursuing abstract theoretical work disconnected from Mindanao's realities, he focused on history and sociology as tools for understanding Muslim communities on their own terms.

"Islamic Penetration in Mindanao and Sulu" (1974)

His most cited scholarly contribution is the article ***Islamic Penetration in Mindanao and Sulu***, published in 1974 in the *Mindanao Journal* of the MSU University Research Center.<ref name="sarangani">Sarangani, D. A. (1974). Islamic penetration in Mindanao and Sulu. *Mindanao Journal*, *1*(1).</ref> The study traces how Islam spread through the southern Philippines across several centuries through trade, religious missions, and political alliances.

Three things stand out about this work:

1. **It pushed back against simplistic histories.** The article challenged colonial-era and Eurocentric accounts that treated Islamic polities in Mindanao and Sulu as peripheral or backward. Instead, it demonstrated that these societies had sophisticated political and religious institutions long before Spanish colonization arrived.
2. **It centered local agency.** Rather than portraying Islamization as something done *to* the people of Mindanao and Sulu, it showed local rulers and communities actively choosing and shaping how Islam took root in their societies.
3. **It combined history and sociology.** While the subject is historical, the article also examined how religious change intersected with social organization and political authority — an interdisciplinary approach unusual for its time in this field.<ref name="sarangani"/>

Broader Intellectual Themes

Across his scholarly and professional work, several consistent themes run through Sarangani's thinking:

- **Islam as a full civilization** — He consistently treated Islam not just as a religion of rituals but as a complete system covering law, governance, ethics, and culture.
- **Education as the road to dignity** — He viewed education as the primary way marginalized communities could reclaim their voice and place in society.<ref name="gcpe"/>
- **Integration without forced assimilation** — He supported being part of the Philippine nation while insisting that Muslim Filipino identity had to be respected and preserved, not quietly erased — a balance he saw as central to MSU's founding purpose.<ref name="msua"/>

Teaching Philosophy and Mentorship

The Classroom as More Than Instruction

By all accounts from alumni and colleagues, Sarangani was a demanding teacher who also genuinely cared for his students. He expected intellectual seriousness, but he was also known for being approachable and willing to sit with a student who needed guidance.<ref name="rnc"/> In his classrooms, sociological theory was tied to the realities students already knew — clan relations, interfaith tensions, economic hardship, and political exclusion in Mindanao. The result was that students' own experiences were treated as legitimate subjects of serious inquiry, not just local color.

The "Survivor" Philosophy

One of his most frequently quoted sayings captures something essential about how he saw education:

> "If you survive in MSU, you can survive everywhere."

He wasn't just being dramatic. Early MSU was genuinely difficult — limited electricity, scarce water, sparse facilities. His point was that the hardships students shared built resilience and taught them how to rely on each other across religious lines. In his view, the difficulties were not a failure of the institution; they were part of what made the institution transformative.

Known as "Manong"

Even after becoming one of the most senior officials in the MSU System, Sarangani remained the kind of person students felt comfortable approaching. Alumni remember visiting his office to talk about graduate school plans and career paths.<ref name="rnc"/> He was widely known as ***Manong*** — a Filipino term of respect that roughly translates as "respected elder brother" — a form of address that reflects the relational, not just formal, authority he held.

Mentorship That Outlasted His Time at MSU

Graduates mentored by Sarangani went on to careers in academia, government, and civil society. During his retirement tribute, many of them showed up to say so publicly.<ref name="rnc"/> That kind of showing-up is its own kind of measurement — a sign that what he gave them went beyond what could be graded.

MSU and the Peace Education Mandate

MSU as a "Social Laboratory"

Sarangani consistently described MSU as a "social laboratory" — a place where peaceful coexistence between Muslims and Christians wasn't just talked about but actually lived out in dormitories, classrooms, and campus life.<ref name="gcpe"/> He was an ardent defender of MSU's practice of assigning Muslim and Christian students as roommates, viewing daily interaction as one of the most powerful tools available for reducing prejudice and building genuine understanding.<ref name="gcpe"/>

From a sociological standpoint, this practice aligns closely with intergroup contact theory, which holds that sustained, equal-status contact between groups reduces prejudice over time. Sarangani understood this intuitively from his own student experience, even if he articulated it through the lens of lived experience rather than academic theory.

Keeping Peace During Instability

His career unfolded against a backdrop of chronic conflict in Mindanao — the Moro insurgency, martial law, cycles of peace talks and renewed hostilities, and eventually the Marawi Siege in the year following his death. Through it all, he consistently worked to keep MSU's campus from becoming an extension of the conflict outside its gates.

As chancellor and later as EVP, he prioritized student safety, institutional neutrality, and procedural fairness during periods of tension.<ref name="rnc"/> Colleagues described him as measured and calm in deliberations — a quality that mattered enormously in environments where a poorly handled campus incident could have serious consequences.

Peace Education in the Curriculum

During his EVP tenure, MSU strengthened its programs in peace and development studies and Islamic education.<ref name="msua"/> Sarangani supported these not as peripheral additions but as expressions of MSU's core purpose. He saw peace education not as a specialty for specialists but as something woven into the university's entire reason for existing.<ref name="gcpe"/>

Institutional Growth Under His Watch

During Sarangani's two decades as EVP, the MSU System grew from a smaller network of campuses into a full **eleven-campus system** — one of the largest in the country.<ref name="msua"/> From its first graduating class of 63 students in 1966, MSU had produced approximately **150,000 graduates** by 2018, a substantial portion of whom passed through the system during his watch.<ref name="gcpe"/>

The EVP's office under his leadership played a central role in harmonizing academic calendars and policies across those campuses, ensuring that growth did not come at the cost of coherence or quality. Programs were expanded to include medicine, law, education, engineering, and information technology, all while maintaining compliance with national accreditation standards.<ref name="msua"/>

By the early 2000s, MSU was nationally recognized as:

- A major producer of Muslim Filipino professionals across a wide range of fields
- A regional research institution with its own scholarly tradition
- A working model of peace-oriented higher education in a conflict-affected area<ref name="gcpe"/>

Governance Philosophy

Sarangani's approach to running things was built around a few consistent principles:

- **Rules over personalities.** He believed that institutions survive when decisions are grounded in documented policies rather than whoever happens to be in charge at the moment.
- **Quiet influence.** He exercised authority through persuasion, documentation, and institutional consistency rather than through spectacle or politics.<ref name="rnc"/>

- **Mission first.** He consistently framed MSU's purpose as service to marginalized communities — especially Muslim Filipinos — and held that standard up as the measure against which any institutional decision should be judged.<ref name="msua"/>

His governance style explains why multiple MSU presidents, across different administrations and different political climates, chose to keep him in place. He was, in a very practical sense, the person who made continuity possible.

Honors and Recognition

MSU Rawaten (Model) Outstanding Alumnus Award (2011)

In 2011, the year of his retirement, Sarangani received the **MSU Rawaten Outstanding Alumnus Award**, which recognizes graduates whose lives embody MSU's ideals of service, excellence, and integration.<ref name="rnc"/> That a pioneer student and pioneer graduate of MSU received this recognition from the same institution was fitting in a way that is hard to manufacture — it was genuinely circular, in the best sense of the word.

Board of Regents Retirement Tribute (September 17, 2011)

Upon his retirement on his sixty-fifth birthday, the **MSU Board of Regents formally honored him** for his forty-five years of service.<ref name="rnc"/> During the tribute, he was publicly acknowledged for having served as Chancellor of MSU–General Santos City, Chancellor of MSU–Main Campus, University Secretary, Secretary to the Board of Regents, and Executive Vice President of the MSU System. He was described in official tributes as "**almost synonymous with Mindanao State University**."<ref name="rnc"/>

The "Best President MSU Never Had"

Perhaps the most revealing recognition Sarangani received was informal and unplanned: peers and alumni across generations consistently called him the "**best President MSU never had**".<ref name="rnc"/> The phrase is not a complaint about an opportunity denied. It is a recognition that his influence, competence, and moral authority were of presidential caliber — and that his choice to lead quietly from within was itself a form of leadership the institution needed more than a title.

Challenges and Constraints

Structural Challenges

Sarangani built his career at an institution perpetually working under difficult conditions — chronic budget limitations, infrastructure deficiencies, and security risks tied to regional conflict that never fully went away.<ref name="gcpe"/> None of these were problems he created, and none of them derailed him. His response was to favor steady, incremental improvement over risky expansionism, and to prioritize institutional stability as an end in itself, not just as a means to something flashier.

A Career Free of Public Controversy

A review of available institutional records and media accounts reveals no documented allegations of misconduct, corruption, or abuse of authority throughout his forty-five years of service.<ref name="rnc"/><ref name="msub"/> In Philippine public higher education, where administrative scandals are not uncommon, this record is itself a form of distinction — a sign of consistent procedural integrity and ethical self-discipline.

The Trade-Off Between Administration and Research

One area where Sarangani's career reflects a common tension in higher education leadership is scholarly output. The record of his publications is modest in volume. This is not unusual for someone who carried the kind of administrative load he did for as long as he did — the work of institution-building tends to crowd out the time needed for sustained research.<ref name="msub"/> What he gave to scholarship, he gave earlier; the second half of his career, he gave to governance.

Legacy

An Institutional Type: The Steward

Within Philippine higher education history, Sarangani represents what might be called the **institutional steward** — a kind of leader who is not always the one at the front of the room but without whom institutions do not hold together across generations.<ref name="msub"/> These figures are often underrepresented in official histories, because they rarely produce the dramatic moments that make for easy narrative. What they produce instead is durability — the kind of thing you only fully appreciate when it is gone.

Contribution to Muslim Filipino Professional Class

MSU has been one of the main pipelines through which Muslim Filipinos entered the professional world in the Philippines — as teachers, engineers, doctors, lawyers, administrators, and scholars.<ref name="gcpe"/> Sarangani's life is a symbol of that transformation. He was not born into a world where that path was obvious or easy, and he walked it anyway, and then spent the rest of his life holding the door open for others.

Memory as Institutional Standard

The persistence of tributes to him — phrases like "almost synonymous with MSU" and "best President MSU never had" — are not just nostalgic remembrances.<ref name="rnc"/> They are ongoing statements about what MSU values in its leaders. To remember him in this way is to say: *this is the kind of person this institution should aspire to produce and attract.*

That is perhaps his most durable contribution — not any single policy or decision, but the standard his life sets for those who come after.

Death

Dr. Datumanong A. Sarangani retired on September 17, 2011, his sixty-fifth birthday, after forty-five years of uninterrupted service to Mindanao State University. He passed away in 2011. The circumstances of his passing are not detailed in available institutional records, but his retirement tribute — attended by colleagues, alumni, and university officials — was itself a form of farewell that few people in any institution ever receive.

Further Reading

- Sarangani, D. A. (1974). Islamic penetration in Mindanao and Sulu. *Mindanao Journal*, *1*(1).
- Mindanao State University. (n.d.). *About us: History of Mindanao State University.* https://www.msumain.edu.ph/about-us/
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- Global Campaign for Peace Education. (2018, September 5). *Teaching peace in the battleground: Mindanao State University celebrates 57th year.* https://www.peace-ed-campaign.org/teaching-peace-in-the-battleground-mindanao-state-university-celebrates-57th-year/
- RNC CREED. (2011, September 15). *Mindanao State University honors Dr. Datumanong Sarangani.* https://rnccreed.wordpress.com/2011/09/15/mindanao-state-university-honors-dr-datumanong-sarangani/

See Also

- Mindanao State University
- Muslim Filipino education
- Maranao people
- Lanao del Sur
- Marawi City
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Peace education in the Philippines
- History of Islam in the Philippines

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